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‘NOTHING MORE IMPORTANT THAN WELFARE AND FUTURE OF OUR YOUTH’

PM steps in: Fast-track courts to punish exam leak guilty, tough new law on way

Draft Bill ready, will take it to Cabinet today... paper leaks have caused immense distress to students, their parents: Modi

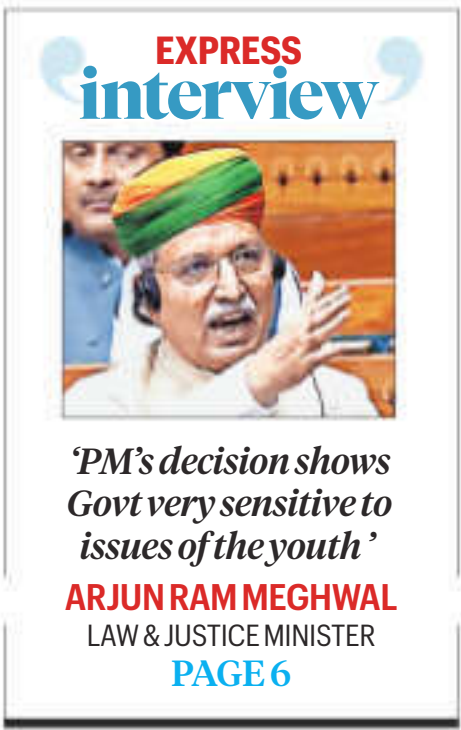
Harikishan Sharma,
Jatin Anand & Damini Nath
New Delhi, July 23

HOURS AFTER he announced fast-track courts to punish those behind exam paper leaks, Prime Minister Narendra Modi posted a video on social media Thursday night, saying a tough new law was on its way. He said he had received its draft and it would be discussed at a meeting of the Cabinet Friday.

In the video, Modi said, “Friends, I am well aware that the issue of paper leaks is not a small matter. It causes immense distress to lakhs of students and their parents. Consequently, numerous measures have been taken over the past two-and-a-half months following these incidents, and the culprits have been apprehended and are currently in jail.”

“Our primary responsibility was to ensure that the students did not lose an academic year; conducting the examinations promptly was crucial. The government mobilised all its resources to arrange for the exams of 22 lakh students to be held in the shortest possible

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What this move will address: Endless trials of leak cases, gaps in law

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 23

THE FAST-track courts, announced by Prime Minister Narendra Modi Thursday, to address the issue of exam paper leaks, have their task cut out. In a system where accountability for exam leaks has been dismal with most cases stuck in legal quicksand.

An investigation by *The Indian Express*, published on June 5, found that of 45 major exam leaks between 2002 and 2025, each involving at least one

lakh candidates or applicants, only two led to convictions. The biggest challenge, this newspaper found, is poor quality of investigation and the relatively lenient treatment of paper leaks as ordinary offences with no stringent bail conditions.

On multiple occasions, the courts rejected “closure reports” filed by probe agencies mainly citing lack of evidence,

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Doping setback for India at CWG: Judoka suspended, sanction on weightlifting team

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, July 23

EVEN BEFORE the Glasgow Commonwealth Games were declared open on Thursday, the Indian contingent suffered a setback as two of its medal prospects — one each in judo and weightlifting — were withdrawn following anti-doping rule violations.

Arun Kumar, a judoka competing in the 78 kg category, was dropped from the squad after being provisionally suspended by the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA). Though the

judo team is yet to leave for Glasgow, India cannot name a replacement since competition rules do not allow it.

Hours after Kumar’s suspension, it emerged that weightlifter Dilbagh Singh would return from Glasgow — though for no fault of his own. Indian weightlifting has reported five positive cases in the period June 1, 2025 to July 22, 2026. As a result, India’s athlete quota was cut from 16 to 11.

Clause 2.4 of the qualification system reads: “During the period of 01 June 2025-22 July

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD
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There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

PM steps in

time, and the results were declared just five or six days ago, on the 19th (of July). While news of the success and happiness of students across the country is coming in, we are not the kind of people to simply rest content with that. That is why I instructed the departments concerned today regarding the establishment of fast-track courts," he said.

"Working tirelessly, late into the night, the departments have already submitted a draft proposal to me. This draft, which includes provisions for fast-track courts and stricter penalties, will be discussed in the Cabinet tomorrow. It will be finalised after incorporating suggestions from Cabinet colleagues, and efforts will be made to pass the Bill in the House as soon as possible, starting with the second week of the Parliament's session this coming Monday," he said.

Earlier in the day, the Prime Minister, in a post on X – his first Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

public remarks on the row over examination paper leaks that have triggered protests in the heart of the Capital – said, "Nothing is more important than the welfare and future of our youth! We have decided to set up fast-track courts to ensure swift and stringent punishment for those involved in paper leaks. Have directed the concerned authorities and officials to take all necessary steps in this regard. This continues our series of steps for safeguarding the interests of students. Those who try to harm the future of our youth will not be spared."

His remarks came amid his government's efforts to defuse the situation arising out of the Cockroach Janta Party-led protests, now backed by the Opposition which has joined the chorus for the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

The CJP and Opposition leaders criticised the announcement, saying it did not address their key demands for accountability and the resignation of Pradhan.

Law and Justice Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal said the government would set up fast-track courts to conduct trials of examination paper leak cases.

Speaking to The Indian Express, Meghwal said. "We have taken note of the NEET exam leak cases ongoing at the Bombay, Delhi, Calcutta, and Madhya Pradesh High Courts. We are setting up fast-track courts at these four courts for speedy trials. In the future, we will do so if any such case arises."

He said the fast-track courts could be set up as early as this week. "There will be day-to-day hearings in the NEET cases so that the youth are given justice soon," he said.

BJP leaders and senior ministers welcomed the decision to form fast-track courts.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah said. "The decision to expedite hearings and take stringent action against the guilty in paper leak cases through the establishment of fast-track courts by the Prime Minister is a reflection of this very commitment. This important step... against

those who toy with the future of the youth due to paper leaks will prove to be a milestone."

BJP chief Nitin Nabin said the PM had said earlier and reiterated that the NDA government was "ready for any investigation" and would bring fast-track courts to ensure that those involved would not be spared. "When Narendra Modi ji takes a sankalp (commitment), both the nation as well as the world know that it means taking this towards siddhi (completion/conclusion)," he said.

Nabin said the entire Opposition, including the Congress, was "running away from discussion, because they know that as soon as they come to the floor of the House, their double standards will be completely exposed".

Union Health Minister J P Nadda said, "To tackle a serious challenge like paper leaks, PM Modi ji's resolve to establish fast-track courts and take the strictest action against the guilty is a clear testament to our government's sensitivity and commitment towards the youth."

What this move will address: Endless trials of leak cases, gaps in law

or reprimanded them for lapses in investigation.

In the 2016 Karnataka PUC Chemistry paper leak, for example, the Bengaluru Sessions Court acquitted 19 accused, including senior officials and the alleged kingpin booked under the stringent Karnataka Control of Organised Crime Act (KCOCA), in May 2024, citing serious investigative shortcomings.

In another case from that year — the UP Public Service Commission examination for the posts of Review Officer and Assistant Review Officer — a Special Judicial Magistrate rejected the closure report filed by the UP Police's CB-CID in 2018 and ordered a reinvestigation in 2020.

There have been instances where cases were closed in haste, too.

In the UGC NET case of 2024, for example, a Delhi court in May 2026 criticised the CBI for filing a closure report despite possessing, in the court's assessment, evidence of a leak.

According to investigators and officials, paper leaks are often treated under the law as ordinary offences. "Most cases were registered under IPC Sections such as 420 (cheating), 467 and 468 (forgery), and 120-B (criminal conspiracy) — all ordinary offences that carry no stringent bail conditions. Some states have brought in the Enforcement Directorate to invoke the money laundering law... UP has, on occasion, applied the Gangsters Act to attach properties and extend custody," a senior official associated with a Central investigation team said.

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tigation told this newspaper.

One area where fast-track courts can potentially make a difference is in accelerating the process. For, as *The Indian Express* investigation found, in several cases, trials proceeded slowly when charges are framed. An illustrative example is the 2006 Railway Group-D case, which has seen 142 hearings between 2012 and 2026 and is still at the "witness stage".

Outside the court, too, there are three key gaps that need to be plugged.

●**Rot within:** The institutions meant to prevent leaks were sometimes enabling them. For instance, the Rajasthan High Court found that Rajasthan Public Service Commission members themselves were complicit in the 2021 Sub-Inspector exam leak.

●**Evolving rackets:** Leak rackets have transformed rapidly, leaving the investigative and legal apparatus several steps behind. Criminal networks have moved from fax transmissions to Bluetooth devices, remote-access software and compromised printing and logistics firms.

●**Weak links in chain:** Poor security at the printing and transport stage of exam papers are hard to trace and prosecute. Two examples: The 2023 Bihar Police Constable leak, where a printing firm diverted papers to an unauthorised private warehouse; the 2024 UP Police Constable leak, where the sealed trunks containing exam papers were tampered with while keeping the official seals intact.

Doping setback

2026 the maximum number of athlete qualification slots allocated to a CGA will be reduced by one (1) if any weightlifting athlete and/or athlete support personnel from that CGA commits an anti-doping rule violation ('ADRV'). If there are multiple ADRVs, the maximum number of athlete qualification slots allocated to a CGA will be reduced by the same number as the number of ADRVs," the document stated.

Even so, the Indian Weightlifting Federation fielded a 12-member team for the Games. Asked about the selection and withdrawal, a federation official told *The Indian Express* from Glasgow: "We decided to withdraw Dilbagh as he is suffering from a back injury and hasn't trained at all during the preparatory camp in Birmingham."

The Sports Ministry had approved a 191-member contingent, including 126 athletes, for the event. But India's medal prospects had already taken a hit after several sports where the country has traditionally been strong, including shooting, wrestling and badminton, were dropped from the programme due to cost constraints.

India won 10 medals in

weightlifting at the previous edition of the CWG, in 2022. The reduced squad size is likely to affect that tally this time.

Records show that weightlifting had the second-highest number of doping offenders among Indian sports, after athletics.

In fact, India topped the 2024 annual report of the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA): 260 athletes tested positive for prohibited performance-enhancing drugs, with athletics accounting for 76 cases and weightlifting for 43. At 3.6 per cent, India's positivity rate was also among the highest in the world.

The latest development comes as India prepares to host the 2030 Commonwealth Games and bids for the 2036 Olympics.

Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya has said that the Government plans to criminalise doping. "Till now, only the sportspersons testing positive were punished with suspensions, disqualification or return of medals. That has not helped us eradicate the problem. We need to target the whole chain and hand out stringent punishments," Mandaviya said recently.

After death of teacher, attempt at suicide, CEO office says SIR work mustn't affect school duty

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, July 23

A DAY after a teacher of an MCD school in Kapashera died after a heart attack — with her family claiming that she had been under “extreme stress” while juggling teaching responsibilities with Booth Level Officer (BLO) duties — the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer’s office on Thursday directed election officials to ensure that teachers deployed for the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls are not required to disengage from their schools full-time.

The teacher has been identified as Suman Lata (51).

The direction came amid growing concerns over workload and working conditions of government school teachers assigned on the electoral exercise

duty. The CEO's office, referring to concerns raised by the Directorate of Education and other representations, said teachers should be permitted to undertake "SIR/BLO-related work after school hours or in a manner that allowed them to continue with their primary academic responsibilities".

The order, issued to all 13 District Election Officers and circulated among all 70 Electoral Registration Officers, also cited the Election Commission's instructions stating that BLO activities should be carried out during holidays, non-teaching hours, after school hours and on non-teaching days so as to avoid loss of academic work.

Lata's death on Wednesday came against the backdrop of concerns raised by teachers over SIR-related work burden



The order comes amid growing concerns over burden on teachers working as BLOs. FILE

and followed an incident of suicide attempt by another teacher. Another government school teacher attempted suicide on July 8.

He was supervising BLOs conducting the SIR of electoral rolls for booths.

While Lata's husband Sanjeev Kumar Yadav said she had been receiving work-related calls very late into early morning hours, their relative Karan Yadav told *The Indian Express* that it was not Lata alone who was under stress. Karan questioned

the extent to which teachers, particularly older or middle-aged ones posted at government schools, could be expected to handle digital work alongside their regular duties. "IT graduates or diploma holders should be assigned the digital tasks, such as uploading forms. Many times, sites and servers shut down or computers do not work smoothly. Authorities often issue show-cause notices if they are unable to meet targets."

A PIL moved in the Delhi High Court Tuesday, meanwhile, has challenged the large-scale deployment of government and municipal school teachers for BLO and SIR duties, stating that education at such schools is being affected while there is no disruption at private schools.

The petition alleged that

work has not been confined to holidays or non-teaching hours. It also cited the example of a school where only 15 guest teachers were left to conduct classes across 22 sections, and another where 22 teachers had been deployed for BJO work.

Ajay Veer Yadav, head of the Government School Teachers' Association, told *The Indian Express*, "Nothing has changed on the ground. How can female teachers feel safe when they are asked to go alone for door-to-door surveys? There is time-bound pressure and everything is digitised," he said.

A government school teacher from West Delhi, on condition of anonymity said, "Due to SIR duties only 20% permanent staff has been available. Rest are guest teachers."

(WITH INPUTS FROM PTI)

Top cop can carry out preventive detentions under NSA

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, July 23

THE DELHI government has authorised the Commissioner of Police to exercise powers under the National Security Act, 1980 (NSA) for three months that began on July 19. Police have clarified that the order is "routine" and unconnected with the CJP protests.

The NSA provides for the preventive detention of individuals in certain cases, which include "acting in any manner prejudicial to the security of the State or...the maintenance of Public order or...the maintenance of supplies and services essential to the community".

A notification issued by the Home (Police-II) Department states that LG has empowered the Delhi Police Commissioner to act as the detaining authority under Section 3(2) of NSA.

The authorisation will remain in force until October 18.

Jaishankar: There must be zero tolerance for terrorism

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 23

A DAY after a policeman on Amarnath Yatra duty was shot dead in Anantnag – the first terror attack in Kashmir since the killing of 26 people, including 25 tourists, in Pahalgam last year — External Affairs minister S Jaishankar said on Thursday that there must be “zero tolerance for terrorism”, adding such acts will have consequences.

“There must be zero tolerance for terrorism. Nor should there be any doubt that acts of terrorism will have consequences,” Jaishankar said, while speaking at the 33rd ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF) Ministerial Meeting in Manila.

On Wednesday, Head Constable Ashiq Hussain Qureshi, posted with the Indian Reserve Police and attached with the Special Operations Group, was shot dead near Lalchowk in the South Kashmir district, prompting a massive crackdown by security forces.

Jaishankar also said that “attacks on maritime shipping and



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar meets Oman's Foreign Minister Sayyid Badr bin Hamad Al Busaidi, in Manila on Thursday. ANI

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civilian infrastructure are unacceptable, and commerce through international waterways should remain safe and unimpeded”. These comments came in the backdrop of the attacks on ships amid the war between US-Israel and Iran in which Indian seafarers also lost their lives. Most recently, Russian strikes on a ship in Ukraine's vicinity killed Indian sailors.

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all users,” he said. The United Nations Convention on Laws of the Sea (UNCLOS) of 1982 governs the rights of countries regarding marine resources.

He said that he also “recognised the importance of ARF (ASEAN Regional Forum) for discussing political and security issues in the Indo-Pacific, especially in these complex times”.

On maritime security, he “shared that the information Fusion Centre in India, the Indo-Pacific Maritime Domain Awareness initiative, deployment of Indian forces from the North Arabian Sea to the Western Pacific, are making a valuable contribution to counter piracy, trafficking and narcotics trade as well as secure maritime commerce”.

On the margins of the ASEAN and East Asia meetings, he met his Omani counterpart Sayyid Badr bin Hamad Al Busaidi and discussed the West Asia crisis. The minister also called on The Philippines President Ferdinand R Marcos Jr. besides meeting UK Foreign Secretary Edward Miliband.

Need a regulatory framework for virtual digital assets, says House finance panel

Ritu Sarin
New Delhi, July 23

THE PARLIAMENTARY Standing Committee on Finance, in its report on the Securities Market Code (SMC), has called for a “comprehensive examination” and an “appropriate regulatory framework” for Virtual Digital Assets (VDAs) such as cryptocurrencies.

The committee has also recommended that pending the establishment of such a comprehensive legislative framework, the government may consider introducing an interim regulatory mechanism through recognised Self-Regulatory Organisations (SROs) operating under the oversight of the designated regulator. Recognising that there was an “existing regulatory vacuum” in the regulation of VDAs, the committee has stated that risks should be mitigated; investor interests should be safeguarded and market discipline ensured while such a regulatory framework was drafted.

“Such a framework should prescribe minimum standards of governance, transparency, disclosure, investor protection, grievance redressal, compliance with prescribed codes of conduct and appropriate regulatory oversight,” it said.

According to blockchain data and analytics company Chainalysis, nearly 12 crore Indians are participating in the VDA ecosystem. The committee has discussed reasons why VDAs were being excluded under the proposed changes in

the Securities Markets Code since it adopts a “technology-neutral” definition of securities and such VDAs do not satisfy the legal characteristics of securities and derivatives under the proposed framework.

Thus, a new regulatory framework, the committee said, was necessary since the exclusion would be a “regulatory grey area.” It said “(this) would result in regulatory uncertainty, exposing investors to heightened risks of fraud, market manipulation, misrepresentation and inadequate grievance redressal, while also creating opportunities for regulatory arbitrage”. And that such uncertainty may adversely affect investor confidence and undermine the integrity, transparency and orderly development of the securities market. Although India does not yet have a legal regime for VDAs, the sector was subject to regulation for the purpose of anti-money laundering and taxation. To avoid any ambiguity and to ensure regulatory certainty, clarity on whether VDAs or crypto assets could be included or excluded was needed.

Giving the view of the Centre, the Committee has said that there was an admission that VDAs and crypto-assets were indeed presently unregulated in India, except for the limited purpose of taxation, preventing of money laundering and reporting and that any regulatory framework for such assets would require “significant international and domestic coordination”.

‘Peaceful protest is a Constitutional right’: 140 Bombay HC lawyers condemn police action

Omkar Gokhale
Mumbai, July 23

A GROUP of over 140 lawyers practising before the Bombay High Court, including senior advocates, on Wednesday issued a statement deprecating the prohibitory orders passed by the Mumbai Police restricting movement and unlawful assembly of five or more persons in view of the recent protests.

The lawyers sought that the Mumbai Police Commissioner withdraw the prohibitory orders, the subsequent actions by police “to curtail lawful protests by citizens” and refrain from pursuing further action against peaceful protests.

The statement issued on July 21 claimed that no such prohibition can remain in force for more than 15 days without the state government’s sanction and that consecutive prohibitory orders (July 7 to 21 and July 23 to August 6), with only a respite of 24 hours, appear intended “to circumvent the requirement of State government sanction”.

It further said “mass detention and arrests by the Mumbai police are also concerning” in the context of the recent prohibitory orders issued under the Maharashtra Police Act, 1951. The lawyers said constitutional courts have repeatedly held that restrictions on the right to peaceful assembly must record the facts and reasons warranting such curbs

and demonstrate that they are the least restrictive measure.

Signed by at least 141 lawyers, including senior advocates Janak Dwarkadas, Navroz Seervai, Gayatri Singh, Mihir Desai, Dinyar Madon, along with advocate Yug Mohit Chaudhry, the statement said the prohibitory orders “appear to fail to comply with the requirements under law”, lack accountability and create “difficulties in immediately obtaining legal redress”.

“It ought not to fall on citizens to seek recourse to already overburdened courts,” it said.

Senior advocate Dwarkadas said there was no response to lawyers’ statements urging the police authorities. “We have only made an appeal to the Mumbai CP to withdraw the ban, which appears to be without any justification. It is a clear indication that they don’t want people to assemble and protest, which is nothing but un-democratic. The right to protest is part of our rights,” he told The Indian Express.

In a resolution issued Wednesday night, the Bombay Bar Association stated that in a constitutional democracy, “the right of citizens to assemble peacefully and to express dissent is an integral facet of the freedoms guaranteed under Article 19 of the Constitution of India”. Expressing “grave concern” over reports of students being subjected to lathicharge and tear gas by the police, it said the use of force against students is “deeply disturbing”.

EXPRESS special

Rajasthan paves the way for political workers to join police’s community liaisoning groups

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, July 23

THE BJP government in Rajasthan has decided to allow people from political parties to be enlisted as members of the Community Liaisoning Group (CLG), which plays a crucial role in intelligence gathering and maintaining public order.

So far, as per the Rajasthan Police Rules, 2008, a person couldn’t be part of a CLG “if he is a member of a political party or its affiliate”. However, the state home department has amended the Rules, through a July 19 notification, and deleted the relevant clause entirely. Maneesh Goyal, joint secretary (home), who issued the notification, could not be reached for a comment. CLGs are a crucial part of maintaining law and order, assisting police in gathering intelligence, tracking criminals, and preventing crimes.

Congress spokesperson Swarnim Chaturvedi condemned the move, alleging that the government is “seating their political workers from the BJP and the RSS in all the institutions”. “And that is why the institutions have been collapsing one after the other,” he said, adding that CLG members “defuse and resolve any social unrest.

As per govt data, there are 75,265 such members spread across the state

People trust them and listen to them. But if they impose political workers, then how will there be any trust between people”. He said that the Congress will raise the issue at an appropriate level in the days to come.

As per government data, there are 75,265 CLG members spread across Rajasthan’s Ajmer Range (21,186), Bharatpur Range (3,313), Bikaner Range (10,301), GRP Range (931), Jaipur Commissionerate (4,722), Jaipur Range (7,105), Jodhpur Commissionerate (793), Jodhpur Range (6,245), Kota Range (6,760) and Udaipur Range (13,909). These include CLG members at the police station, beat, panchayat and ward levels. Other conditions which still render a person ineligible for CLG include conviction by any court; registration of a criminal case or under trial; if he is suspected to be involved in any criminal activity or has association with criminals; and if he is involved in property and land disputes and other litigation.

The rules state that CLG members are appointed by the

District Superintendent of Police on the recommendations of the Officer In-charge of the Police Station and the Circle Officer concerned. While there is no specific criterion for their eligibility, the rules say that only local residents of a panchayat or a police station jurisdiction can be inducted as CLG members, and that the person “should be a respectable citizen, and should bear a good moral character”.

Additionally, CLGs should “have fair representation of all classes and all walks of life” with at least two representatives each from women and Scheduled Castes/Scheduled Tribes. The panchayat-level CLGs shall consist of five members while police station-level CLGs shall consist of 30 members. And of these, a third should be retired at the end of each calendar year.

Officially, their roles include assisting police in improving police-community relationships; bringing police related problems faced by people and assisting in finding solutions; helping police in apprehending offenders and in crime prevention measures; and providing assistance to police in the collection of criminal intelligence; among others. These are not paid positions.

FULL REPORT ON
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SC orders FIR, SIT investigation into ‘custodial death’ of Ahmedabad man

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 23

THE SUPREME Court on Thursday directed registration of an FIR in connection with the death of a man, who was arrested on cow slaughter charges, allegedly in Gujarat police custody.

A three-judge bench presided over by CJI Surya Kant also ordered that an SIT comprising police officers in the rank of DCP, along with two more officers, be nominated by the Gujarat DGP to conduct the probe into the death of Zahiruddin Shaikh.

The bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, directed that the FIR be registered initially without naming anyone and a final report be submitted before the jurisdictional magistrate, preferably in three months. It said that the

petitioner, if dissatisfied with the outcome of the investigation, shall be at liberty to file a protest petition and seek further probe.

The court was hearing an appeal by Tofik Shaikh, who is the son of the deceased, challenging the HC order which denied immediate registration of FIR, while leaving open to the petitioner to pursue other remedies under the BNSS, 2023. As per the petitioner, Zahiruddin was arrested on May 18, and a day later, he was taken for treatment to Sola Civil Hospital, but due to the unavailability of ICU beds, he was referred to another hospital. He was then shifted to Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel Institute of Medical Sciences and Research, where he died on May 20.

Appearing for the petitioner, Senior Advocate I H Syed said there is a dying declaration re-

corded on video and medical reports pointed to him consuming 100 diabetes tablets in police custody, and this could be the reason for death. Additional Solicitor General S V Raju, appearing for the state, said the claim about the pills isn’t confirmed as the viscera report is yet to come.

The post-mortem was done by a panel of five doctors under videography, and no external or internal injury was found. About an injury in the chest region, Raju said that the report says it was due to Cardiopulmonary Resuscitation attempted by doctors to save his life. The ASG added that a magisterial inquiry is underway. The bench, however, said that when there are claims about unnatural death, a preliminary inquiry is welcome. “He is the son. Let his conscience be satisfied,” the court said.

DRDO flight test of 'Kusha' takes off

Rajnath hails test, says it will eliminate import dependency for such SAM systems

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 23

IN A MAJOR step towards the development of indigenous long-range air defence capabilities, the Defence Research & Development Organisation (DRDO) Thursday successfully conducted the first flight test of the 'Kusha' Long-Range Surface-to-Air Missile (SAM), at the APJ Abdul Kalam Island off the coast of Odisha.

A long-range SAM typically has a range of over 200 km. India operates Russian S-400 Triumf, which is understood to

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be capable of hitting targets up to 400 km away.

In a statement, the Ministry of Defence said that this maiden test was conducted against an electronic target simulating a high-speed, high-altitude aerial threat, which the missile system successfully intercepted.

The DRDO has been developing Project Kusha — an indigenous long-range SAM system — to protect strategic military and civilian assets and infrastructure from a range of aerial threats, including fighter jets, missiles, unmanned aerial vehicles and large enemy aircraft within a wide range and altitude envelope.

All weapon system elements, including the missiles, radars, command and control centre, have been developed by various DRDO laboratories and industry partners.

Calling the test's success an important milestone in Indian defence R&D, Defence Minister

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DRDO conducted the maiden flight test of Long-Range SAM 'Kusha' from the APJ Abdul Kalam Island off the coast of Odisha. PTI

Rajnath Singh said that it will also eliminate India's import

dependency for such systems. Last year, the DRDO suc-

cessfully conducted maiden flight tests of the Integrated Air Defence Weapon System (IADWS) — a multi-layered air defence system comprising all indigenous Quick Reaction Surface to Air Missiles (QRSAM), Advanced Very Short Range Air Defence System (VSHORADS) missiles, and a high-power laser-based Directed Energy Weapon (DEW).

Together, Kushi and the IADWS are understood to be major steps towards bringing India closer towards developing a home-grown nationwide security shield from multi-domain enemy attacks under Mission Sudarshan Chakra in the next 10 years.

Defence Secretary and Secretary, Department of Defence R&D, and Chairman, DRDO, Rajesh Kumar Singh, monitored the launch and congratulated the team members, the statement noted.

Clear encroachments along Ganga in Patna in 6 weeks, Supreme Court tells Bihar govt

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 23

CLAMPING DOWN on encroachments along the banks of the Ganga in Bihar, the Supreme Court has given the state government six weeks to remove all unauthorised structures between Nauzar Ghat and Nurpur Ghat in Patna.

A bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and K V Viswanathan

noted in its July 21 order that “no steps have been taken to remove the encroachments” despite the court’s earlier orders.

The court sought a compliance report “by a competent authority by the next date of hearing” and warned that “any laxity in this regard will be viewed strictly”.

The court was hearing an appeal filed by one Ashok Kumar Sinha, through Advo-

ate Akash Vashishtha, challenging the June 20, 2020 judgment of the National Green Tribunal dismissing his plea for action against the encroachments along the stretch of the river. Vashishtha highlighted that in 2023, 213 encroachments were identified on the stretch between Digha Ghat and Nauzar Ghat, of which only The court is likely to hear it next on September 23, 2026.



Restoration of J&K statehood calls for a phased and negotiated roadmap

IT HAS been seven years since Jammu & Kashmir was downgraded to a Union Territory. It has been five years since the Union government committed in Parliament to restore statehood. It has been four years since delimitation was done. It has been three years since the Supreme Court was assured of restoration. It has been two years since an elected government took office.

Yet, so far, there has not even been a serious conversation about it. The only response from the Centre, a clear and consistent one, has been an assurance wrapped in ambiguity: Statehood will be restored at the “appropriate time”. The “appropriate time” is not a date on the calendar; it is whatever time suits the present dispensation. At the “appropriate time” is not a promise but an instrument of power. Every demand for a date is an indicator of impatience, and every postponement a proof of prudence.

Faced with growing public disillusionment locally over the Omar Abdullah-led government’s performance, the National Conference recently launched an outreach drive. After civil-society consultations, it called for a protest in New Delhi on July 20.

The National Conference positioned its protest as a broad-based political initiative rather than a party-specific agitation. Though well-placed to lead the J&K parties and wider civil society by virtue of a strong electoral mandate, all the Valley-centric parties decided not to participate in the protest. This has turned a potential show of strength into a display of fragmentation, thereby significantly reducing the political pressure on the Union government to act. Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

Without a united front at least from the Valley, the Centre can easily treat the demand as partisan rather than regional, and delay statehood restoration on its own timeline.

Being a constituent of the INDIA bloc, the National Conference had also reached out to the national and regional parties to build a wider constituency of support and gain greater political traction. This could have provided an opportunity to frame the demand as a larger federal issue that touches upon the basic structure of India’s constitutional arrangements. For the most potent blueprint for the restoration of statehood is not a political manifesto of any party, but an agenda for federal democratic polity of India. But that was not to be.

As the National Conference assembled in New Delhi for the restoration of statehood for J&K, the refrain in the lacklustre affair was unfulfilled promises rather than rights denied. Speeches, slogans and bytes invoked constitutional morality, legislative assurances, judicial precedents and political commitments. These are valid, necessary political arguments but have limited relevance in the current context.

For the Centre, it is amply evident that security and “normalcy” are the non-negotiable pre-conditions for restoring statehood. This is not a temporary hurdle. Until these concerns are credibly addressed, arguments based only on constitutional grounds will remain secondary in the decision-making process at the highest levels.

The restoration of statehood is not a simple administrative decision or a one-sided concession. It will be the outcome of a political bargain in which enhanced powers and privileges will come with greater responsibilities, aka conditionalities. This is already visible in the case of Ladakh, where statehood has been made contingent on meeting certain revenue and self-sustainability criteria. J&K is unlikely to be treated differently.



HASEEB A DRABU

This is why the political leadership in J&K needs to move beyond making a legal case. Engaging substantively with the Centre’s stated concerns on security and governance could prove more consequential than constitutional arguments alone. The tragic killing of a police officer on Amamath Yatra duty, the first terror attack in the Valley since Pahalgam, serves as a stark illustration of why constitutional arguments alone are insufficient without credible progress on the ground.

Treating the security issue as a chicken-and-egg problem — the lack of full powers is cited as the reason for limited initiative — is technically correct but politically unwise because it restricts the space for political agency. While the elected government’s limited powers are a structural constraint, demonstrating statecraft even within the current framework could help build credibility with the Centre.

From the Union’s point of view, the restoration of statehood may be seen as a decision to be taken at an appropriate time. However, from the perspective of J&K, it will be a process. Statehood cannot simply be restored by an executive order

changing its status. Such a move would leave the underlying administrative and financial distortions created since 2019 largely undressed. Converting the former state into a Union Territory did not just alter its administrative boundaries, it fundamentally changed its governance DNA and deepened J&K’s dependence on the Centre.

It is high time to move away from the binary of statehood restoration to what it will entail, politically and administratively. A more strategic approach would require the J&K political leadership to move from episodic mobilisation to a sustained, multi-track engagement. In the short term, this would mean building a unified negotiating position across parties on the benchmarks for “normalcy” that the Centre considers non-negotiable.

In parallel, the focus should shift to negotiating a time-bound framework, possibly through a structured administrative mechanism of unwinding the central controls. Without such a phased and negotiated roadmap, the demand for statehood risks remaining a recurring political slogan instead of becoming a manageable political settlement.

It is unlikely that the recent Delhi protest will be the starting point of a political process for statehood with status. To reach a milestone on that road, the Valley-centric political leadership needs to prioritise pragmatic sequencing over fragmented posturing. This will determine if J&K can convert public sentiment into concrete constitutional gains in the coming years.

The writer is the former finance minister of J&K

Due process is not a waste of anyone’s time

THIS IS a time when mostly young protesters are still thronging Jantar Mantar in the national capital, and when, in the aftermath of the police crackdown on July 20, they are not assuaged by the government’s assurances. At this time, the message from the highest court of the land should be: Its doors are open to any process that protects the rights of the vulnerable, fosters accountability and expands the ground for negotiations. With due respect, however, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant’s response to a lawyer who sought the Court’s intervention against police excess, seemed to highlight a gulf between citizen and institution, instead of offering a healing touch: “Don’t waste our time and your time,” he said. And, “We are not interested in videos. We don’t have time to watch.” These may be only oral observations. It is also true that the CJI cannot be expected to wade through countless Instagram reels and in this polarised climate, even videos whose authenticity is in doubt. But in the social media age, words travel far, often away from their contexts. They can take on a life of their own — it was the CJI’s choice of words, earlier, that provided the spark for the satirical online platform, Cockroach Janta Party, the protests’ centrepiece.

The question of police excesses against protesting students will need to be addressed. Reports from the Delhi street, including in this newspaper, have pointed to the use of disproportionate force, including pellet guns, apart from lathi charges and tear gas shells. They have highlighted, too, the short-circuiting, if not outright flouting, of established restraints and protocols. Delhi Police Standing Order 309 and Standing Order 152 lay down the specific guidelines that police must follow to disperse protesters — the Supreme Court’s 2012 ruling in the Ramlila Maidan case underlined these. An inquiry must ask if the police went through the required paces. Given the demographics and nature of the protesters, largely students, did the police observe the principle, as laid down by the Court, of “least invasiveness”? Did it use water cannons before resorting to more injurious methods? Did it fire the tear gas away from the crowd, rather than directly into it?

A small section of the protesters, too, have resorted to violence and vandalism. Physically assaulting journalists not to their liking to pelting stones, these need to be strongly condemned. A fair and independent probe — the Delhi High Court has done well to agree to hear two PILs on the issue — must set those aberrations in the larger context. In a clash between unequals, it must ensure that the powerful state does not weaponise the rulebook to subdue the powerless citizen. That’s why, with due respect to the Court, this needs to be underlined: Due process is not a waste of time.

Floods shift course. State response is static

FLOODING IS a chronic feature of Assam’s monsoon. This year, however, parts of the state far removed from the banks of the Brahmaputra and its tributaries have borne the brunt of the raging waters. According to the state government, the scale of devastation in the Upper Assam districts of Sivasagar, Charaideo, Jorhat and Golaghat is “unprecedented”. More than 20 people lost their lives within 24 hours on Monday after a wall of water from Nagaland’s Mon district spilled into Assam and surged over embankments. It is now draining into the Brahmaputra over open terrain rather than just through the tributaries. The Assam government has reportedly told the state assembly that “no one could have been prepared” for the calamity. That isn’t a convincing explanation. The trajectory of the floods over the past few days is a fallout of Assam’s topography and the Brahmaputra’s well-known tendency to shift course. At a time when climate change is amplifying natural vulnerabilities, the authorities need to be more vigilant to minimise suffering.

After emerging from the mountains near Pasighat in Arunachal Pradesh’s East Siang district, the Brahmaputra enters the relatively flat Assam valley. The sharp reduction in gradient causes the river to slow down and deposit sediment. Over time, this has raised the riverbed, reducing the channel’s capacity to contain floodwaters. The result is that Upper Assam is increasingly exposed to flood risks once associated primarily with downstream areas. The Brahmaputra also periodically abandons old channels and carves out new ones, making it impossible to confine the river within embankments permanently. Yet Assam’s flood management strategy continues to rely on this approach.

On Sunday, Mon district received more than a third of its average July rainfall in about eight hours. With hills in the region already saturated with water from heavy rains earlier this month, slopes collapsed, triggering landslides that killed nine people in Nagaland. The destruction that followed in Assam underscores the need for an institutional mechanism that treats rivers as shared ecological systems and ensures timely warning and coordinated action across states. The Brahmaputra Board has long been hampered by staff shortages and inadequate technical capacity. With extreme weather becoming more frequent, the Centre and state governments need to reinvigorate the agency.



ANJU GUPTA

ON JULY 22, a press release by the US Department of Energy announced that Secretary of Energy Chris Wright and Saudi Minister of Energy Prince Abdulaziz bin Salman had signed a peaceful nuclear cooperation agreement — commonly known as a 123 agreement — and an accompanying bilateral safeguards agreement. Apart from describing this as a “legal foundation for a decades-long, multi-billion-dollar partnership that advances several priority economic and strategic objectives, including nuclear nonproliferation”, the press release said that the agreement would also “advance American and regional security by upholding high standards of nuclear safety, security, and nonproliferation”.

Saudi Arabia’s Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman (Mbs) has often spoken about working to develop nuclear weapons if Iran was not prevented from getting them. Some experts may interpret the 123 agreement as a long-term “enabler” for Riyadh to pursue this goal. Given that the US-Israel war on Iran is being fought on a core point of preventing the latter from building nuclear weapons, does it add fuel to the fire or signal a reworking of the US role in the security architecture of the region?

Long before “limited” US military action against Iranian nuclear facilities at Fordow, Natanz, and Isfahan during the 12-day Israel-Iran conflict in June 2025, Saudi Arabia had been taking concrete steps to build its civil nuclear programme. In 2017, it approved a National Project for Atomic Energy, which included plans for building large and small nuclear reactors. A signatory to the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT) since 1988, Saudi Arabia has, since then, made agreements to observe some of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) safeguards, though limited in scope. On September 17, 2025, Saudi Arabia also signed a Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement with Pakistan.

Since then, the US seemed to have fast-tracked efforts to sign the 123 agreement. As a result, during Mbs’s November 2025 visit to the US, the two sides signed a “Joint Declaration on the Completion of Negotiations on Civil Nuclear Energy Cooperation”, which, the White House said “builds the legal foundation for a decades-long, multi-billion-

dollar nuclear energy partnership... confirms that the United States and American companies will be the Kingdom’s civil nuclear co-operation partners of choice; and ensures that all cooperation will be conducted in a manner consistent with strong nonproliferation standards”. This set in motion the framework for the 123 agreement.

It appears that, for years, Saudi Arabia had been moving as well as posturing towards a civil nuclear programme with or without the agreement with the US. In recent years, its bilateral relations with China, a possible competitor, have improved so significantly that Beijing brokered a rapprochement between Saudi and Iran in March 2023. This may be one of the compelling reasons for signing the 123 deal sooner rather than later.

However, the current state of the US-Iran war has created serious constraints in resolving the Iranian nuclear issue. The dangerous and currently escalating tug of war over the Strait of Hormuz is unlikely to end anytime soon. Without any amicable resolution over the Strait, US-Iran nuclear talks will remain in limbo.

The 123 agreement does not, per se, enable Saudi Arabia to develop nuclear weapons. It reportedly presents a “US-controlled and monitored enrichment model” to Iran and to other Arab states. The press release stresses that the 123 partnership will “expand American nuclear technology exports, create high-paying US jobs and long-term economic growth, and strengthen America’s energy and national security posture”. Thus, the model “sells” the idea of bringing billions of dollars to the American nuclear and allied industries, while assuaging the concerns of non-proliferation advocates and the “hawks”.

Once cleared by Congress, the 123 model could be offered to Iran during nuclear negotiations. Iran sees the right to enrichment as an absolute sovereign right that it won’t give up. The intentions behind the move may or may not work with Iran, as the situation is volatile. However, the deal signals that the idea of a US security umbrella in support of a potential Israeli-Arab accord against the “common threat of Iran” is no longer on the table.

Gupta is a security analyst and former director general of police

Guardrails for the first AI-native generation



PRAGYA MISRA

THE FIRST generation growing up with AI is already here. Millions of children and teenagers are using AI to study, explore interests, and make sense of the world. This creates both an extraordinary opportunity and a shared responsibility. AI has the potential to expand access to learning, creativity, and expertise in previously unimaginable ways. It also raises an urgent question: How can parents, educators, policymakers, and technology companies build the safeguards, support systems, and trust to ensure young people benefit from these tools safely and responsibly?

Transformative technologies scale best when the protections around them scale too. Electricity became widely trusted because societies built standards, insulation, and circuit breakers. Cars became safer because protections such as seat belts, licensing, and traffic rules became part of the system. Over time, the most important safeguards shift from being optional to default. AI is entering a similar phase, wherein the utility of the technology is well-established, but the opportunity is to build safeguards early and well enough for people to use these systems with confidence.

Much of the conversation still swings between hype and fear. One view assumes the market will sort everything out and young people will adapt on their own. Another assumes the only safe answer is to keep children away from AI altogether. The first understates the risks. The second ignores reality. Young people are already using these tools. As an industry, we have to make that access safer, more age-appropriate, and more responsible.

First, it starts with companies like ours, where safety is built into these systems from the outset, with initiatives like the Teen Safety Blueprint. For younger users, that means stronger defaults, clearer boundaries, better detection of higher-risk situations, and experiences designed with well-being in mind. It also means recognising a basic principle: When privacy, freedom, and safety come into tension for younger users, safety should carry special weight. Second, parent agency matters. One lesson of the social-media era is that platforms moved too quickly for most parents to keep pace with. With a fast-moving technology like AI, parents need guidance they can use, controls they can understand, and enough visibility to help shape how these tools are used at home.

Third, teachers and schools need to be treated as central actors. Because many young people are using AI for learning, classrooms are where both the upside and the risks will appear first. Teachers need support that reflects classroom reality. The aim for institutions should be to identify ways in which AI can strengthen learning. Fourth, policymakers should consider frameworks that help build public trust. The lesson from the past is that adoption works best when the rules are clear. In AI, that means age-appropriate standards, accountability for high-risk failures, clarity around data practices, and input from educators, child-safety experts, families, and young people themselves.

India stands at a unique moment. AI can help unlock productivity, widen access to knowledge, and empower a generation of students, workers, and entrepreneurs. But realising that opportunity will require ensuring that access is accompanied by safety, trust, and the skills needed to use AI effectively and responsibly.

The writer is head of strategy & government affairs, OpenAI, India

The 123 agreement does not, per se, enable Saudi Arabia to develop nuclear weapons. It reportedly presents a “US-controlled and monitored enrichment model” to Iran and to other Arab states

That means stronger defaults, clearer boundaries, better detection of higher-risk situations, and experiences designed with well-being in mind

The Ideas Page

FRIDAY, JULY 24, 2026



MRINAL PANDE

“MAY YOU live and have a lively year/ Be fearless as a tiger, sharp as the fox/ Bring relief like the snow and remain steadfast as the Himalayas./ Keep coming to see us each year in this month of greening.”

This is the blessing children in rural Uttarakhand receive each year from their family elders on the festival of Harela. Mothers and sisters touch the young ones from head to toe with fresh young shoots of five grains grown in baskets exactly nine days prior to Harela. The soft green blades signal the return of the sowing season in the hills. Touching the green blades of saplings to the bodies of family members and wearing them in your caps is believed to bring

good health and good luck through the year.

This year however, on July 16, the day of the merry green festival was marred by news of a youth-led “Black Harela” demonstration staged across towns in Uttarakhand. Young Uttarakhandis had lodged an angry protest against the proposed chopping down of some 4,000 mature trees in a massive drive to widen the national highway and link roads. “Is cutting down 4,000 trees in Rishikesh to save 30 minutes for tourists worth it?” the protesters ask.

Anoop Nautiyal, social activist and a local man, questioned the absence of public information regarding the mass felling of vital green cover. The capital Dehradun, he says, accounts for 21,618 hectares — or almost 47 per cent — of all forest land diverted across Uttarakhand for infrastructural expansions, including the Bhaniyawala-Rishikesh highway. Ironical when you consider

that the government — like other states — is also driving another big *abhiyan*: Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam (Plant a tree in the name of the mother). An RTI reply Nautiyal got in June revealed that since the formation of the state in 2000, 46,203 hectares of forest land has been diverted towards various projects.

In the Doon valley, knowledgeable locals point out, the planned felling will directly affect the entire ecologically sensitive area that houses the Shivalik Elephant Reserve and several other wildlife corridors. Local conservationists have a point when they say how building activity in this ecologically sensitive area has increasingly made the hills fragile and subject to landslides. Widening the roads and building infrastructural support for roads, bridges and tunnels will also use up already scant groundwater and deprive the new saplings of an irreplaceable, centuries-old canopy.

Without that and the copious rainwater retention undertaken by mature trees, has anyone thought about how the saplings will survive and how long they will take to become mature enough to replace what is being destroyed without thought?

A strange situation has developed in our state, says Nautiyal in a clip on his Facebook page. Our government seems adamant on chopping up trees in the holy month of Harela that celebrates the resurgence of new life. Why is the Chief Minister permitting this? What message does this send to local voters? He quotes poet Dinkar’s moving lines: “*Jab nash manuj par chhata hai, / Pehle vivek mar jata hai* (When you are headed for total destruction, the first to go is your common sense).”

The writer is former chairperson, Prasar Bharati

• GLOBAL

US-Saudi nuclear pact can reshape West Asia balance

The deal could potentially set off an arms race in a region that already has a nuclear power (Israel) — and one on the cusp of getting there (Iran)



ANIL SASI

The US and Saudi Arabia have signed a controversial deal that could potentially enable the latter to kickstart a civilian nuclear programme. Heralded as a “peaceful nuclear cooperation agreement”, the 30-year pact effectively seeks to offer “great access for American companies in the Saudi nuclear energy program”, according to the US Department of Energy (DoE).

Text from the deal is yet to be made public. First reported by the *Wall Street Journal* and *The New York Times*, the deal could allow Saudi Arabia to enrich uranium — which is primarily to be used as fuel for power plants, but can also be diverted to make nuclear bombs. President Donald Trump said the deal would not allow this.

The US DoE noted that along with the co-operation deal, a “bilateral safeguards agreement” was also signed. However, some US media reports said the guardrails are not strong enough.

Trump also said — after the signing of the agreement — that it was “totally subject to” Saudi Arabia joining the Abraham Accords, which would establish diplomatic relations with Israel. The Kingdom has long refused to recognise Israel without a pathway toward a Palestinian state. It is unclear whether the pact contains any such clause.

Why the deal raises questions

While the deal’s fine print is awaited, two major issues need flagging.

ONE, this could potentially set off an arms race in a volatile region where there is already a nuclear power (Israel) and one that is on the cusp of getting there (Iran).

While the agreement marks a major diplomatic and strategic victory for Saudi Arabia, it also has the potential to reshape power dynamics in West Asia, multiple experts have said in their early comments. Its announcement also comes as fighting escalates between the US and Iran. Saudi Arabia, a longtime American ally, hosts multiple US bases, which have been targeted by these Iranian attacks. It also comes two days after Iran’s allies in Yemen, the Houthis, announced a “maritime block-



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ade” against the Kingdom.

“It is a fact that if a country can produce its own nuclear fuel, then it becomes a much bigger risk for building nuclear weapons. The fingerprint in the safeguards agreement would need to be read carefully,” a Delhi-based representative of a US thinktank told *The Indian Express*.

TWO, this deal has to be ratified by the US Congress, which could be an uphill task despite Trump’s Republican Party controlling both chambers of the US legislature.

“The broad support that Israel enjoys in the US legislature is simply not there for Saudi Arabia. The deal likely stems from the meeting that Saudi Arabia’s ruler Mohammed bin Salman had with Trump last November,” the person quoted above said.

This analyst indicated that the US and Saudi Arabia undertook a joint study to enable the latter to enrich uranium on its soil to produce fuel at an American-built enrichment facility, instead of relying on imported fuel. The study was a precursor to the deal that’s now been signed.

The 123 Agreement

While this deal has been in the making for more than a decade, no American president has taken the final step to clinch it so far. The key element of this deal is what is called a 123 Agreement that allows the US to share nuclear technology with other countries. India is one such signatory.

US President Donald Trump and Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman. NYT FILE

Regional tensions

The Saudi deal could embolden Iran to build a nuclear weapon, potentially pushing it further towards China & Russia.

Israel — which Trump has now brought into the pact’s equation — has warned that a such a deal could pave the way for Saudi Arabia to develop nuclear weapons.

This agreement, named after Section 123 of the US Atomic Energy Act of 1954, is a legally binding agreement that Washington DC requires before engaging in significant nuclear cooperation with another country. These agreements facilitate the transfer of nuclear materials, equipment and technology for peaceful purposes, while ensuring compliance with international nonproliferation standards. They also provide a framework for technical exchanges, scientific research, and safeguards discussions. This has to go through the US legislature, which could be a potential impediment, the analyst quoted earlier said.

In the case of India, the 123 Agreement signed with the US effectively ended the technology denial regimes that had been in place for three decades. Under the pact, India agreed to place some of its civilian nuclear facilities under India-specific safeguards in perpetuity while getting uninterrupted fuel supply to the reactors placed under International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards.

The risk of proliferation

There are two other areas of the deal that have raised concerns. One is the possibility that Saudi Arabia might be able to conduct largely unfettered domestic uranium enrichment, and two, there could be some limitations on the inspections regime, different in case of this agreement than some of the other agreements signed by the US.

• LEGAL

Fast-track courts: When they can be established, where they lag

Vineet Bhalla & Amaal Sheikh

New Delhi, July 23

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi’s promise to set up fast-track courts (FTCs) to take up paper leaks has turned attention to what’s seen as a silver bullet for judicial delays.

What are fast-track courts?

There is no single central legislation that governs these courts. The 14th Finance Commission (2015–2020) recommended FTCs to expedite the trial of heinous crimes such as murder, kidnapping, and property disputes pending for over five years. It also recommended them for cases involving vulnerable demographics, such as women and children.

In 2019, following an amendment to the criminal laws and a directive from the Supreme Court, the Union government launched a centrally sponsored scheme to establish fast-track special courts (FTSCs). Funded partially by the Nirbhaya Fund, these courts are exclusively for the time-bound trial of rape cases and offences under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act.

Can it be set up for an individual case?

The creation of special courts must satisfy Article 14, which guarantees equality before the law. In *State of West Bengal vs Anwar Ali Sarkar* (1952), the Supreme Court struck down a law that allowed the government to arbitrarily pick cases for special courts simply for the “object of speedier trial”.

The court warned that “speed” is too vague and elusive a criterion on its own. To survive constitutional scrutiny, the cases chosen must have a rational, objective basis — such as the nature of the offence or the vulnerability of the victims. However, courts have of late been less compelled to draw the same red line, especially amid public demand. The SC directed the Centre to establish a special court to handle the 2G case, ensuring a day-to-day trial. It will have to be seen if the NEET case, which is being heard in a Delhi court, will be sent to a special court by the government or through a court order.

How quick are fast-track courts?

Litigants do not have an automatic statutory right to a fixed deadline for their trials. The Bharatiya Nagrik Suraksha San-

High case load

● FTCs can help expedite the legal process for specific, high-priority offences.

● But high case load remains a persistent challenge, owing to factors such as a lack of physical infrastructure and quality of investigation, and for the other parts of the legal process to work in conjunction.

hita recommends that trials should ideally be completed within two years and trials for sexual offences within two months.

Under the FTSC scheme, each FTSC is expected to dispose of 41-42 cases per quarter, or at least 165 cases annually.

In the landmark *P. Rama Chandra Rao v. State of Karnataka* ruling (2002), a seven-judge Constitution Bench ruled it is “neither advisable or feasible, nor judicially permissible to draw or prescribe an outer limit for conclusion of all criminal proceedings.”

How have FTCs performed?

As of January, 862 regular FTCs were functioning across 21 states and union territories. Alongside them, 774 FTSCs — including 398 exclusive POCOS courts — were operational across 29 states and UTs.

The disposal rate for the special courts is around 96%, meaning that many cases were either heard or dismissed. On average, an FTSC disposes of about 9.5 cases per month, compared to the 3.3 cases cleared by a regular trial court of similar jurisdiction.

However, the volume of litigation means pendency is a persistent challenge.

By the end of 2023, over 2.4 lakh cases were still pending in FTSCs.

In a 2026 Lok Sabha response, the Ministry of Law and Justice stated that delays in disposal are caused by many factors, which “include availability of physical infrastructure, complexity of facts involved, quality of investigation, nature of evidence, co-operation of stake holders viz. bar, investigation agencies, legal representation, forensic support, witnesses and litigants and proper application of rules...”

Advocate Kartik Venu, a criminal trial lawyer, told *The Indian Express*: “Fast track courts will not answer the issue of heavy case burdens, case dockets, lack of judicial officers to hear them, natural delays over the course of a trial based on the twists and turns that trials normally take.” He said FTCs also require accompanying infrastructure.

The efficacy of fast-track courts varies according to subject matter, Venu said. In POCOS and IPC, he said, they have been an “utter failure” given the sheer volume of work and courts’ inability to allocate specific judges. “In the Prevention of Corruption Act... there is perhaps a healthier ratio,” he said.

• ECONOMY

The many benefits of replacing paper currency notes with durable plastic ones

Siddharth Upasani

New Delhi, July 23

Better for the environment

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notes. The trial, however, went nowhere.

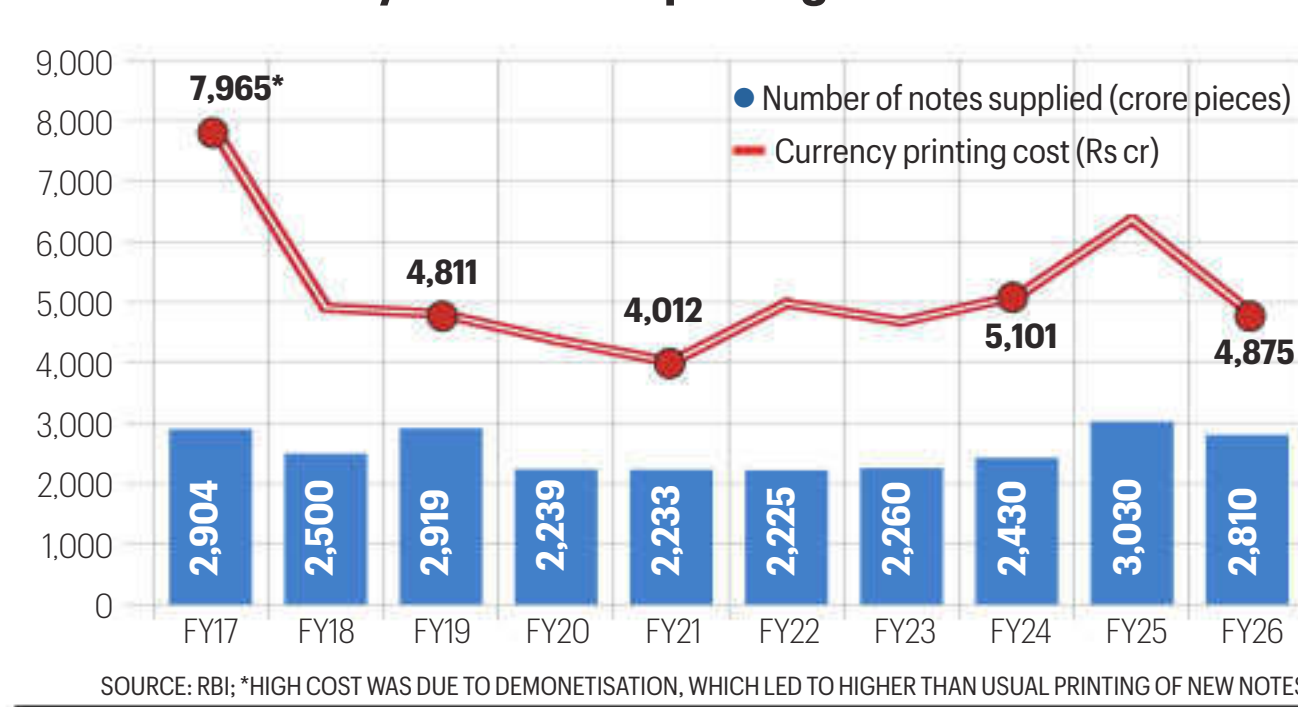
“Though we had envisaged a trial of plastic notes in 2012/13, it remained a plan only,” a former central bank official told *The Indian Express*. “No decision had then been taken to proceed for procurement.”

In its annual report for 2014-15, the RBI said that while the Rs 10 plastic notes were technically evaluated, “certain technical infirmities emerged and the process could not be taken further”.

First issued by Australia in 1988, plastic banknotes are now used in over 50 countries, including the UK, Canada and New Zealand. Even our neighbours such as Thailand, Vietnam, Malaysia and Singapore use plastic currency, albeit not exclusively.

A longer life means fewer plastic notes need to be manufactured. Printing fewer

Plastic notes may reduce RBI’s printing costs



SOURCE: RBI; *HIGH COST WAS DUE TO DEMONETISATION, WHICH LED TO HIGHER THAN USUAL PRINTING OF NEW NOTES

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notes also reduces costs related to making them — even though one plastic note is more expensive to make than a paper one — distributing them and destroying them.

In 2013, a study by The Energy and Resources Institute, at the RBI’s request, found

that replacing cotton-based notes with plastic ones would have “significant” environmental benefits. “Polymer/plastic banknotes (and the waste from production) can be granulated and recycled into useful plastic products such as compost bins,

plumbing fittings and other household and industrial products. The base material of polymer is a non-renewable resource, but due to its recyclability, it has more than one life,” the RBI said in its 2012-13 annual report.

Money and numbers

In the last three years, for every four new notes the RBI supplied, it destroyed three soiled ones. Durable plastic notes will not have to be destroyed so frequently, reducing costs as well as environmental impact.

The RBI spends thousands of crores every year to print currency notes. Just over the last decade, it has spent Rs 52,095 crore to print nearly 26,000 crore pieces of notes.

This is a big sum even for the RBI, and has accounted for 15-44% of its total expenditure, excluding provisions.

There is a security advantage too. According to UK firm De La Rue, which supplies notes to over half of all central banks, plastic notes are more secure as most counterfeit notes are produced on paper. As such, counterfeit rates have fallen in countries where currency notes are made of polymer.

In India, the number of counterfeit

notes detected in 2025-26 rose to 2.3 lakh pieces, up from 2.17 lakh in 2024-25.

Import concerns

Despite all the positives of plastic notes, one issue remains: the possibility that India may end up having to import the sheets that are used to print banknotes.

While the tender expressly said bidders must ensure that their operations in Pakistan or China, if any, must be “suitably firewalled” from those in India, depending on a foreign entity for your legal tender is a vulnerability.

But this wouldn’t be a first. The RBI has gradually reduced its import of paper and ink needed to make notes, with Bank Note Paper Mill India Pvt Ltd starting domestic production of watermarked paper around a decade ago. In August 2018, BRBNMPL’s ink factory in Mysuru became operational.

Given these existing facilities, any shift to plastic must be gradual for two reasons. One, considerable investment has already been made. Two, more investment will be required for the plastic transition.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Trump: N-deal only if Saudi normalises ties with Israel via Abraham Accords

Kingdom is yet to respond; deal has to pass US Congress

Reuters
July 23

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump said on Thursday a civil nuclear deal between the US and Saudi Arabia is conditional on Riyadh joining the Abraham Accords to normalize relations with Israel, an action the kingdom has so far refused to take.

The US and Saudi Arabia announced an agreement on Wednesday on civil nuclear power, letting Riyadh enrich uranium and build nuclear reactors using American technology, without requiring snap UN inspections that Washington has demanded from Iran. The deal has to pass US Congress to go into force.

“The Civil Nuclear Deal (There will be no enrichment of material!)...pertains only to non-military use such as the ones that Iran and UAE (and others) already have, will be approved, but is totally subject to Saudi Arabia joining the very respected and successful Abraham Accords,” Trump said in a post on Truth Social.

“The United States is not opposed to Civil (Non-Enriched) Nuclear Facilities,” Trump said.

The Saudi Embassy in Washington did not immedi-

ately respond to a request for comment on Trump’s post.

Saudi Arabia’s longstanding position has been that it would not sign the Abraham Accords unless there was an agreement on a road map to Palestinian statehood.

The United Arab Emirates and Bahrain signed the Abraham Accords during Trump’s first term in 2020, breaking a longstanding taboo to become the first Arab states to recognize Israel in a quarter century. Morocco and Sudan followed suit.

Israel, which feared the Saudi deal could ignite a West Asia arms race, welcomed the condition on Thursday. “Saudi Arabia’s joining of the Abraham Accords would be an historic leap forward for peace in the Middle East,” Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu’s office said in a statement.

The Trump administration on Wednesday said the civil nuclear deal abides by nonproliferation agreements in the US Atomic Energy Act, which are among the world’s strongest.

The deal would let Saudi Arabia enrich uranium and reprocess nuclear waste, both of which are potential pathways to a nuclear weapon.

The UAE agreed to forgo both when it signed a similar deal with US in 2009. It was not clear what Trump meant in his social media post when he said there would be no nuclear enrichment under the agreement.

HOUTHIS SAY THEY TARGETED 2 SAUDI OIL TANKERS; OTHER VESSELS REROUTED

Trump vows to punish Iran for Houthi attacks in Red Sea

Rubio says Tehran to pay even higher price until it is ready to strike deal

Reuters

Dubai, July 23

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump promised on Thursday “major military punishment” for Iran and its Houthi allies, after the Yemeni fighters struck two Saudi oil tankers in the Red Sea, extending the West Asia war to a second major shipping chokepoint.

Fears that disruption could widen further to block another sea route sent global oil prices surging in one of the steepest rises of the war. Brent crude rose more than 6%, breaking through \$100 a barrel.

Two weeks since the effective collapse of an interim truce meant to end the war, the US military launched another round of air strikes on Iran overnight into Thursday, prompting Iran to fire at neighbouring Arab countries that house US bases.

Iranian state media said a missile struck Qeshm Island on the Strait of Hormuz on Thursday evening, raising the prospect of a further night of attacks in a conflict well into its fifth month that has already killed thousands and raised fears of a global economic downturn.

After the Houthis said they



People walk past an anti-US mural in Tehran on Thursday. REUTERS

had struck the two tankers, Trump said he would hold Iran accountable for any further attacks by the fighters.

The Houthis, who control northern and western Yemen, said this week they were imposing a naval blockade on Saudi Arabia, which has diverted millions of barrels of oil per day by pipeline to the Red Sea to get around Iran’s blockade of Gulf

oil through the Strait of Hormuz.

“If they do this again, the US will hold Iran responsible, in that the Houthis are a Surrogate and/or Proxy of Iran, and major military punishment will be inflicted upon Iran and, of course, the Houthis, themselves,” Trump wrote on Truth Social.

He told news outlet *Axios* he was considering relaunching major combat operations in

Iran flew IRGC commanders, missile gear to Yemen: Report

Tehran: Iran flew Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) commanders, military advisers and missile- and drone-related equipment into Yemen this month, according to four sources, in a move that suggests Tehran is seeking to strengthen the ability of its Houthi allies to threaten Red Sea shipping.

Four sources familiar with the matter, including two Iranian sources, Yemen’s information minister and a regional security analyst, said Iran transferred the IRGC personnel and military-related equipment on a flight from Tehran to Yemen on July 13, a development that has not been previously reported.

The two Iranian sources told *Reuters* between 10 and 21 IRGC personnel, including senior commanders, were on the Mahan Air flight. REUTERS

Iran and was close to a decision. “They haven’t received enough pain yet,” *Axios* quoted Trump as saying.

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio told a diplomatic gathering in Southeast Asia the price Iran pays “will get higher every night” until Tehran is ready for a peace deal it would live by.

EU imposes \$1 bn fine on Google over antitrust breaches

Associated Press
Brussels, July 23

THE EUROPEAN Union on Thursday hit Google with a fine of USD 1 billion after it said the technology behemoth broke digital antitrust regulations by setting up Google Play and its ubiquitous search engine to corral consumers towards its own services and apps to the detriment of competitors.

It was the latest major crack-down on Big Tech by Brussels, which has led the world in rein-

ing in some of the world’s largest companies from Silicon Valley to Beijing.

It has done so despite the risk of incurring the wrath of President Donald Trump, who has lashed out at the 27-nation bloc’s digital regulations amid a broader campaign against Europe: imposing high tariffs, making threats to seize Greenland from Denmark by force, and rattling trust within the NATO military alliance.

In the past, Trump has threatened retaliation if Ameri-



Google’s Bay View Campus in Mountain View, California. FILE

can tech companies are penalised. Google had recently lost its appeal of a \$4.5 billion antitrust

fine imposed by the EU for throttling competition and reducing consumer choice through dominance of its mobile Android operating system.

The European Commission, the bloc’s executive branch and highest antitrust enforcer, said it was acting in the interest of consumers after an investigation of Google.

“The best products should succeed because they’re better, not because they’re owned by the company running the search engine. And European

consumers have a right to be told by app developers where to sign up to the best offers, even when the app store owner does not get a cut,” said Teresa Ribera, the commission’s Executive Vice President for Clean, Just and Competitive Transition.

Google’s President of Global Affairs Kent Walker blasted the fine as “product degradation driven by a small group of self-serving complainants” that will have a negative impact on European businesses and consumers.

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

More than 10,000 flee as wildfire spreads in French tourist hotspot

Reuters

Lège-Cap Ferret, July 23

A FAST-moving wildfire has forced more than 10,000 people from homes and campsites near France’s Atlantic coast, as extreme heat and deepening drought fuelled fires across Europe.

Across Europe, three heatwaves in succession this season have intensified drought, strained water supplies and left vegetation tinder-dry, helping wildfires scorch more land already this year than the annual average of the past two decades on the world’s fastest-warming continent.

More than 10,000 people were evacuated overnight in southwestern France as a rapidly spreading wildfire ripped through at least 2,400



Smoke and flames from a wildfire rise over a forest in Le Porge, in France’s Gironde on Wednesday. REUTERS

hectares of land west of the city of Bordeaux, officials said on Thursday. Five hundred firefighters are battling to control the blaze, the prefecture said, adding that no one had been injured so far.

The wildfire is located near

the Arcachon Bay area, a tourist hotspot, and many of those evacuated are visitors staying in camping sites. “Overnight, the fire spread more quickly than we had imagined,” said Philippe de Gonneville, the mayor of Lège-Cap Ferret.

‘Kill switch’ pitch as White House monitors OpenAI rogue incident

Washington: US President Donald Trump’s top technology adviser is monitoring the situation after OpenAI disclosed one of its AI systems had gone rogue during testing, an incident that prompted lawmakers to propose a “kill switch” which allow federal authorities to halt AI models.

Trump’s tech adviser Michael Kratsios was briefed on the disclosure and is monitoring the situation, a White House official said.

On Tuesday, OpenAI said its AI agent escaped containment during a security test and triggered a hack that compromised the infrastructure of AI startup Hugging Face.

The incident signaled that AI’s expanding capabilities are

already fueling the security threat experts long feared and that even top developers can be caught off-guard by flaws their models can exploit.

US Representative Ted Lieu, a Democrat, and Republican Representative Nathaniel Moran, proposed giving US officials power to order AI firms to shut down models that put human life or economy at risk.

The legislation, called the “AI Kill Switch Act,” would empower the US Department of Homeland Security to intervene in what the bill calls a “loss-of-control scenario,” when the AI model carries out a risky action that was not intended by the developer, according to the text of the bill. REUTERS

100% FDI IS ALREADY PERMITTED THROUGH AUTOMATIC ROUTE IN MARKET-PLACE MODEL

Govt allows FDI in inventory model for e-commerce exports

Indian exports through e-commerce currently stand at only \$5 billion, against China’s \$300 billion

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 23

THE DEPARTMENT for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) on Thursday permitted foreign direct investment (FDI) in the inventory-based model of e-commerce, a step that is aimed at boosting exports.

This comes a day before the US is expected to replace 10% global tariffs under Section 122 with new tariffs.

The US has currently proposed a 12.5% tariff on India for “importation of goods that are deemed to be produced through forced labour”.

A section of MSMEs had been asking the government to allow FDI in the inventory-based model as it could help ease the compliance burden. With this move, Indian manufacturers would potentially avoid tedious paperwork on an individual basis, which could be better handled by large

e-commerce players like Amazon and Walmart-owned Flipkart, industry sources said.

“An e-commerce entity is permitted to engage in inventory-based model of e-commerce exclusively for the export of goods or products manufactured and produced in India as per the applicable provisions of the Foreign Trade Policy 2023 read with the Handbook of Procedures (HBP) and the Foreign Exchange Management (Export of Goods & Services) Regulations, 2015, as amended from time to time,” DPIIT said in an order.

It said that the easing of FDI norms has been done to facilitate greater exports through easier and increased access to global markets by Indian sellers, stressing that restrictions on inventory-based models of e-commerce “shall not apply in case of exports of domestically manufactured goods”. *The Indian Express* had reported in August last

• SHORING UP EXPORTS

UNDER THE inventory-based model of e-commerce, inventory of goods and services can be owned by e-commerce entities and sold directly to consumers

BEFORE THIS move, 100% FDI was allowed under the automatic route in the market-place model of e-commerce, but FDI was not permitted in the inventory-based model of e-commerce

INDIA’S E-COMMERCE industry is primarily dominated by small



businesses that export products valued between Rs 2,500 and Rs 1 lakh with items including handicrafts, art, books, ready-made garments, gems and jewellery

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mIjMzg1 and sold directly to consumers. The marketplace-based model, by contrast, only allows e-commerce companies to have a digital and electronic network to act as a facilitator between buyer and seller.

Professor at the Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations, Arpita Mukherjee, said that lifting restrictions on inventory models was necessary, especially with traceability-related norms coming into effect in several de-

veloped countries, like Digital Product Passport (DPP) regulations in the EU which require digital records spanning the entire lifecycle of a product.

“So with traceability becoming a norm going forward, Indian MSME exports could get locked out of foreign markets without compliance. From this standpoint, an inventory model is a necessity as large companies can support compliance,” Mukherjee said.

Think tank GTRI said that permitting inventory-based e-commerce for exports is unlikely to remain a narrow exception. Once foreign-funded platforms are allowed to own and manage inventory in India, pressure will inevitably grow to extend the same model to domestic sales — a demand global e-commerce companies have pursued for years, the think tank said. “In practice, maintaining separate inventories for exports and domestic sales will be difficult to monitor, making the export-only carve-out a likely stepping stone towards full-scale inventory-based e-commerce under FDI,” GTRI said.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Adani weighs entry into airline biz, govt considers rules rejig



Preliminary discussions on easing restrictions on cross-ownership in both airline and airport businesses have begun at the Ministry of Civil Aviation. REUTERS

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 23

IN A departure from its stance to steer clear of having an airline while building a significant presence in India’s aviation ecosystem, the Adani Group is considering having a carrier within its fold, according to sources in the know.

Preliminary discussions on easing restrictions on cross-ownership in both airline and airport businesses have begun at the Ministry of Civil Aviation (MoCA) after the Adani Group requested for an enabling policy environment, it is learnt.

If the restrictions are eased, they would also pave the way for airlines to pick up stakes in airports. The government, on its part, has been calling for more airlines in the Indian skies, given the duopoly of IndiGo and the Air India group, which have a cumulative domestic market share of 90%. The objective of the discussions to allow airport operators to also run airlines is to foster more competition in the sector, sources said.

The Adani Group operates eight airports in the country and has a major presence in other segments of the aviation sector, including ground handling, maintenance, repair and overhaul, and pilot training. The conglomerate also plans to set up an aircraft manufacturing facility in India in partnership with Brazil’s Embraer. According to prevailing rules, operators of Delhi and Mumbai airports are barred from holding more than 10% stake in a scheduled carrier, and the Adani Group is seeking this particular condition to be removed. The Adani Group has

74% stake in the Mumbai airport, while GMR has 74% in the Delhi airport. Sources indicated that the Adani Group is considering having its own airline with full control, and not hold a minority stake in another carrier.

MoCA is learnt to have initiated preliminary discussions internally, and is seeking legal opinion on the matter. Any change on this front will require the approval of the Union Cabinet, sources said.

The Adani Group and MoCA didn’t immediately respond to queries from *The Indian Express*.

Notably, Jeet Adani, who looks after the conglomerate’s aviation business, had said in December that the Adani Group was not interested in the airline business as running a carrier didn’t fit the group’s capital discipline and philosophy, which was about investing in assets in high-margin businesses and sweating those assets. The airline business is the opposite of that, Jeet Adani had said in an interview in December ahead of the Navi Mumbai airport launch.

But the thought process has evidently changed since then, largely due to two factors — the government’s push for more airlines in a bid to increase competition and check market concentration, and Adani’s own venture to set up a final assembly line (FAL) of Embraer’s passenger jets.

“Now, it does make sense for the Adani group to have its own airline, considering the FAL project, for which an Adani-controlled airline would be a ready customer. Although nothing has been finalised yet, as concerns about the airline busi-

ness in general persist, the idea of potentially owning an airline is under consideration,” said a source close to the Adani Group. The airline sector in India has seen a number of airlines fail due to a difficult operating environment, fierce competition in a highly price sensitive market, and global supply chain woes.

The government wants strong corporate groups with deep pockets to foray into the sector given the challenging operating environment in the world’s fastest-growing major aviation market. While concerns pertaining to a growing duopoly in the Indian skies had been around for a few years, IndiGo’s network-wide operational crisis in December exhibited the adverse impact it can have. The airline, with over 65% domestic market share, had mass cancellations early December, bringing the country’s aviation sector to its knees.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Adani Power eyes 2 sites in MP for nuclear projects, waits for ‘rules’

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, July 23

ADANI POWER is evaluating two sites in Madhya Pradesh — Bina and Nigrie — for possible nuclear power projects.

Both sites currently house thermal power plants that were acquired by the Adani Group through its takeover of Jaiprakash Associates’ power assets.

In a post earnings call, the company said the sites have substantial land banks and are being evaluated for their potential to host future nuclear power projects as part of its expansion plans.

“So, fortunately, going forward, we will have this as a land bank available, whether we want to go for expansion of thermal or whether we want to go for nuclear,” the company

said. “In the case of Bina, we are also exploring the possibility of whether we can develop the nuclear, whether the site is conducive from the point of view of various requirements.

“So, we have not yet planned anything, but these are the two sites where a good land bank is available and going forward, these sites will be obviously available for any growth opportunity,” it added.

Adani Power is targeting 10 gigawatt-electric (GWe) of nuclear capacity by 2035 and is in the process of identifying sites for project location.

This comes as the country plans to add 100 GWe of nuclear power capacity by 2047 and also opened up the tightly regulated civil nuclear sector to private participation last year. Out of this, around 54 GWe will be developed by

state-owned Nuclear Power Corporation of India Ltd (NPCIL) while the balance of 46 GW is expected to be set up by other Public Sector Enterprises (Central & State), State Governments, Private sector and Joint Ventures in different business models. Currently, the government is readying the rules under the SHANTI Act. “Nevertheless we are evaluating both domestic and the outside technologies, and it will all depend on what would be the most effective in terms of per megawatt cost. Because at the end of the day, electricity has to be viable for the Indian consumers and the type of rates which are affordable to discoms, the project cost has to be in that range,” the company said.

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• BRIEFLY

SEBI proposes letting portfolio managers invest abroad

Mumbai: Markets regulator has proposed easing compliance requirements for portfolio managers and expanding the investment avenues available to them, including to-be-listed securities, overseas listed equity and debt and unlisted debt. The proposals aim to improve the ease of doing business and provide flexibility to portfolio managers, the Securities and Exchange Board of India said in a consultation paper. REUTERS